WHY THE CITY

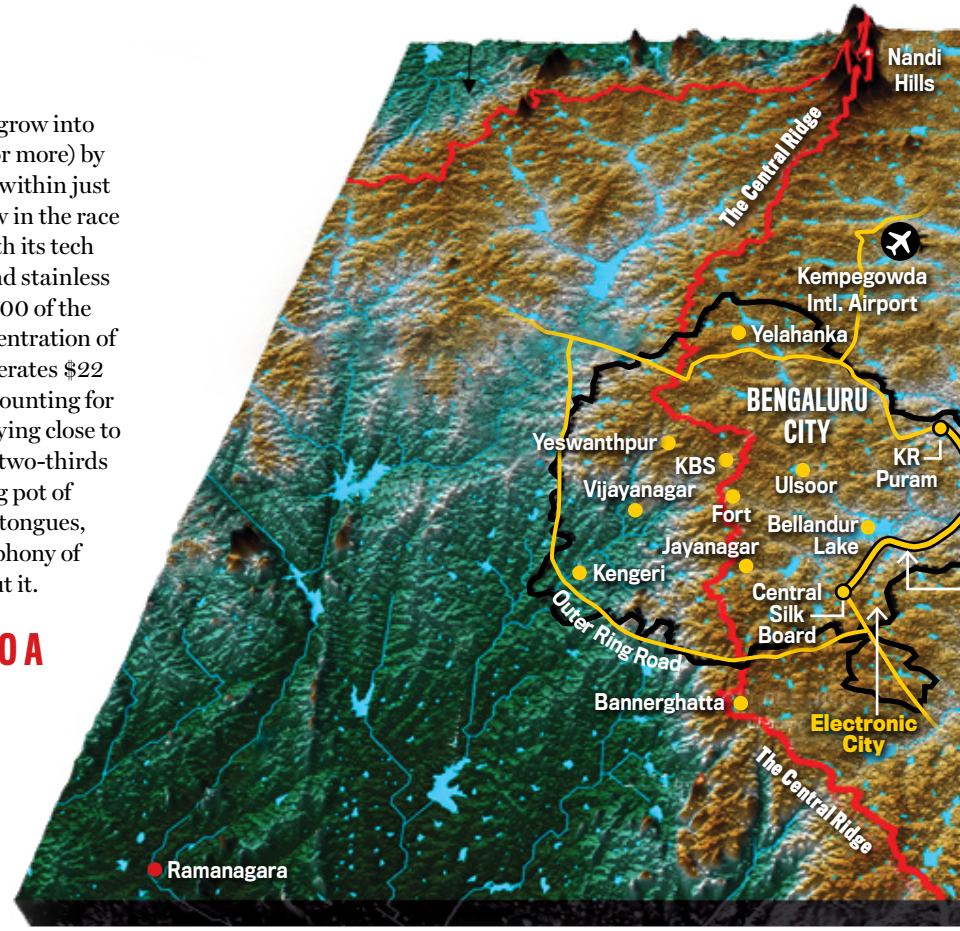
spring up like daisies every morning and grow into unicorns (having turnovers of $1 billion or more) by sundown. Or even decacorns, like Byju's, within just a decade of being set up. Bengaluru is now in the race to be the infotech capital of the world, with its tech corridor, a glittering 17-km arc of glass and stainless steel skyscrapers, housing an estimated 400 of the Fortune 500 corporates. This dense concentration of the world's top IT and banking firms generates $22 billion (Rs 1.8 lakh crore) per annum, accounting for a third of Bengaluru's revenue and employing close to 1 million people. With migrants forming two-thirds of its population, more than just a melting pot of cultures, the 'Multiple City' has a myriad tongues, multiple origins, multi cuisines and cacophony of soundtracks and festivals, as an expert put it.

FROM SLEEPY CANTONMENT TO A CITY THAT DOESN'T SLEEP

Once a laidback pensioners' paradise, the city now has an army of software development and business processing firms chasing the sun to get work done worldwide with their lights burning bright through the night. There are other distinctions, too, to commend the city. It has the highest number of multinational R&D centres, accounting for a third of the 1,165 in the country. Hi-tech capital apart, Bengaluru is also acknowledged as India's science, avionics, space, start-up and biotech capital. The joke is that with Bengaluru's software enterprises running so many of the global computer installations, were the city to get nuked, the world would go back to the Stone Age.

With a per capita income of Rs 5.72 lakh, or four times the all-India average, Bengaluru is one of the most affluent cities in the country. Occupying just two per cent of Karnataka's land area, it contributes a staggering 37 per cent to the Gross State Domestic Product. Yet its prosperity threatens to be the kiss of death for Bengaluru. It took just one major spell of rain in September to expose the city's worst-kept secret—India's most progressive city is regressing at warp speed and, if left unchecked, could see total collapse.

Among those who bore the brunt of nature's fury was Gaurav Munjal, the CEO of Unacademy, the edtech giant, who lives in a posh colony of luxury villas close to Hi-tech City. On September 6, he, his family and his pet dog had to be rescued from their house after flood waters entered it. Uploading a video, Munjal tweeted: "Family and my Pet Albus has been evacuated on a Tractor from our society that's now



Source: Topography prepared by Raj Bhagat P.



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